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humanity, particularly the younger generation.

For the last 50 years, I have lived in India. A homeless person like me found a very happy new home here. Not just that, at a spiritual level, India is truly our home. For thousands of years, we Tibetans have held India at the highest esteem, as our guru. Long back, a Tibetan scholar had described India's influence on us thus: "Till India's light (that means, Buddhism) reached, the land of snow was dark. The light turned the land of the snow bright." So that has been our attitude, always. You have been our guru and we have been the most loyal *chela*. So, logically, if the *chela* is making an effort to spread India's ancient heritage, the guru, too, has some responsibility to make an effort. So here comes my appeal: Think secular. The meaning of secularism in this country does not mean rejection of religion. In the West, there's some discomfort with the word secularism. But India's own Constitution is premised on this. It fits this multi-religious, multi-cultural country, where through centuries, there has been respect for all religions, all ways of life, including that of the

non-believer. If the 20th century was one of violence despite the tremendous progress in science and technology, the 21st century should be the century of dialogue. Conflict is bound to happen. What we can do is to come up with a new method of facing conflict, through non-violence—the idea that Mahatma Gandhi had promoted. This is still very much alive in India. The circumstances are also ripe. At one time, Gandhiji's promotion of non-violence was often wrongly interpreted as passive or as a sign of weakness. But now, the world is really getting more attracted to his non-violent ideals. It's an opportune moment to spread the word.

I am a messenger for India's thoughts. Wherever I go, I am always talking about India—India's gifts to the world—of religious harmony, human values and ahimsa to the world. Ahimsa means action of compassion. So in order to promote compassion, we must look for motivation. And as a messenger, I am appealing to my Indian friends with folded hands today to keep in mind your own traditions. Embrace your own secular values of religious tolerance and ahimsa. I feel, that the time has now come to teach the world. The new world is heavily interdependent. You must take a more active role and export your centuries-old treasures. India has a far greater chance to promote deeper human values for a happier human society, secularly. That, to me, is the new challenge and the new reality. ■

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DISCUSSION

Q. Is there a time when non-violence is not the path to follow?

Dalai Lama: From the Buddhist viewpoint, motivation and goals are more important than methods. So, theoretically speaking, it is possible to use violent methods out of sincere, compassionate motivation and a positive goal. But, practically, it is always dangerous. First, violence can become unpredictable and get out of control. In Iraq, exactly that has happened. Also, violence can control the body, not the mind. In the case of Tibet, our method is non-violent. We also don't

seek full separation from China. Tibet is materially backward. For a modernised Tibet, remaining within an economically more powerful nation is in our own interest. At the same time, we have our own unique cultural heritage to have a meaningful autonomy.

Q. Do you feel that you have not succeeded in your goals?

Dalai Lama: Since March 10, 2008, my faith in the Chinese Government has become thinner and thinner. But my faith towards Chinese people is never shaken. There's a lot of positive support from among

Chinese intellectuals. We always try to reach out to the Chinese people. They are the real rulers of a country. There are signs of change. But our approach of strict non-violence has failed to bring trust from Chinese Government. There is still suspicion and distrust.

Q. As a diehard optimist, what would you expect and hope for Tibet and as an extreme pessimist, what is the worst that can happen to it?

Dalai Lama: Fifty years have gone by. And our slogan is still: "Hope for the best, prepare for the

worst." We have not lost our spirit or determination. Our best hope is to remain within the People's Republic of China and material development for Tibet. We feel that in the minds of millions of Chinese people there is something lacking, an emptiness. We can spread the message of love and compassion. Tibet can help China, the most populated nation, become the most compassionate nation. The worst consequence? Tibet is passing through a death sentence. If the military occupation continues for another 10-15 years, Tibet will be finished. ■